

Chapter IV

The Abbé Fouquet



FOUQUET hastened back to his apartment by the subterranean passage, and immediately closed the mirror with the spring. He was scarcely in his well-known voice crying:—‘Open the door, monseigneur, I entreat you, open the door!’ Fouquet quickly restored a little order to everything that might have revealed either his absence or his agitation: he spread his papers over the desk, took up a pen, and, to gain time, said, through the closed door,—‘Who is there?’

‘What, monseigneur, do you not know me?’ replied the voice.

‘Yes, yes,’ said Fouquet to himself, ‘yes, my friend, I know you well enough.’ And then, aloud: ‘Is it not Gourville?’

‘Why, yes, monseigneur.’

Fouquet arose, cast a look at one of his glasses, went to the door, pushed back the bolt, and Gourville entered. ‘Ah! monseigneur! monseigneur!’ cried he, ‘what cruelty!’

‘In what?’

‘I have been a quarter of an hour imploring you to open the door, and you would not even answer me.’

‘Once and for all, you know that I will not be disturbed when I am busy. Now, although I might make you an exception, Gourville, I insist upon my orders being respected by others.’

‘Monseigneur, at this moment, orders, doors, bolts, locks, and walls I could have broken, forced and overthrown!’

‘Ah! ah! it relates to some great event, then?’ asked Fouquet.

‘Oh! I assure you it does, monseigneur,’ replied Gourville.

'And what is this event?' said Fouquet, a little troubled by the evident agitation of his most intimate confidant.

'There is a secret chamber of justice instituted, monseigneur.'

'I know there is, but do the members meet, Gourville?'

'They not only meet, but they have passed a sentence, monseigneur.'

'A sentence?' said the superintendent, with a shudder and pallor he could not conceal. 'A sentence!—and on whom?'

'Two of your best friends.'

'Lyodot and D'Eymeris, do you mean? But what sort of a sentence?'

'Sentence of death.'

'Passed? Oh! you must be mistaken, Gourville; that is impossible.'

'Here is a copy of the sentence which the king is to sign to-day, if he has not already signed it.'

Fouquet seized the paper eagerly, read it, and returned it to Gourville. 'The king will never sign that,' said he.

Gourville shook his head.

'Monseigneur, M. Colbert is a bold councillor: do not be too confident!'

'Monsieur Colbert again!' cried Fouquet. 'How is it that that name rises upon all occasions to torment my ears, during the last two or three days? You make so trifling a subject of too much importance, Gourville. Let M. Colbert appear, I will face him; let him raise his head, I will crush him; but you understand, there must be an outline upon which my look may fall, there must be a surface upon which my feet may be placed.'

'Patience, monseigneur; for you do not know what Colbert is—study him quickly; it is with this dark financier as it is with meteors, which the eye never sees completely before their disastrous invasion; when we feel them we are dead.'

'Oh! Gourville, this is going too far,' replied Fouquet, smiling; 'allow me, my friend, not to be so easily frightened; M. Colbert a meteor! *Corbleu*, we confront the meteor. Let us see acts, and not words. What has he done?'

'He has ordered two gibbets of the executioner of Paris,' answered Gourville. Fouquet raised his head, and a flash gleamed from his eyes. 'Are you sure of what you say?' cried he.

'Pardon me, my dear marquise; excuse me; yes, M. Colbert is my enemy, I believe him to be so; yes, M. Colbert is a man to be dreaded, I admit. But! I have time, and as you are here, as you have assured me of your devotion, as you have allowed me to hope for your love, as we are alone—'

'I came here to save you, Monsieur Fouquet, and not to ruin myself,' said the marquise, rising—'therefore, beware!—'

'Marquise, in truth you terrify yourself too much at least, unless this terror is but a pretext—'

'He is very deep, very deep; this M. Colbert: beware!'

Fouquet, in his turn, drew himself up. 'And I?' asked he.

'And you, you have only a noble heart. Beware! beware!'

'So?'

'I have done what was right, my friend, at the risk of my reputation. Adieu!'

'Not adieu, au revoir!'

'Perhaps,' said the marquise, giving her hand to Fouquet to kiss, and walking towards the door with so firm a step, that he did not dare to bar her passage. As to Fouquet, he retook, with his head hanging down and a fixed cloud on his brow, the path of the subterranean passage along which ran the metal wires that communicated from one house to the other, transmitting, through two glasses, the wishes and signals of hidden correspondents.

'Well, this pencil was a lead-pencil, consequently hard; so, it marked in black upon the first sheet, and in white upon the second.'

'Go on.'

'Colbert, when tearing off the first sheet, took no notice of the second.'

'Well?'

'Well, on the second was to be read what had been written on the first; Madame Vanel read it, and sent for me.'

'Yes, yes.'

'Then, when she was assured I was your devoted friend, she gave me the paper, and told me the secret of this house.'

'And this paper?' said Fouquet, in some degree of agitation.

'Here it is, monsieur—read it,' said the marquise.

Fouquet read:

'Names of the farmers of revenue to be condemned by the Chamber of Justice: D'Eymeris, friend of M. F.; Lyodot, friend of M. F.; De Vanin, indit.'

'D'Eymeris and Lyodot!' cried Fouquet, reading the paper eagerly again.

'Friends of M. F.,' pointed the marquise with her finger.

'But what is the meaning of these words: "To be condemned by the Chamber of Justice"?'

'Dame!' said the marquise, 'that is clear enough, I think. Besides, that is not all. Read on, read on;' and Fouquet continued,—'The two first to death, the third to be dismissed, with MM. d'Hautemont and de la Vallette, who will only have their property confiscated.'

'Great God!' cried Fouquet, 'to death, to death! Lyodot and D'Eymeris. But even if the Chamber of Justice should condemn them to death, the king will never ratify their condemnation, and they cannot be executed without the king's signature.'

'The king has made M. Colbert intendant.'

'Oh!' cried Fouquet, as if he caught a glimpse of the abyss that yawned beneath his feet, 'impossible! impossible! But who passed a pencil over the marks made by Colbert?'

'I did. I was afraid the first would be effaced.'

'Oh! I will know all.'

'You will know nothing, monsieur; you despise your enemy too much for that.'

'Here is the proof, monseigneur.' And Gourville held out to the superintendent a note communicated by a certain secretary of the Hôtel de Ville, who was one of Fouquet's creatures.

'Yes, that is true,' murmured the minister; 'the scaffold may be prepared, but the king has not signed; Gourville, the king will not sign.'

'I shall soon know,' said Gourville.

'How?'

'If the king has signed, the gibbets will be sent this evening to the Hôtel de Ville, in order to be got up and ready by to-morrow morning.'

'Oh! no, no!' cried the superintendent, once again; 'you are all deceived, and deceive me in my turn; Lyodot came to see me only the day before yesterday; only three days ago I received a present of some Syracuse wine from poor D'Eymeris.'

'What does that prove?' replied Gourville, 'except that the chamber of justice has been secretly assembled, has deliberated in the absence of the accused, and that the whole proceeding was complete when they were arrested.'

'What! are they, then, arrested?'

'No doubt they are.'

'But where, when, and how have they been arrested?'

'Lyodot, yesterday at daybreak; D'Eymeris, the day before yesterday, in the evening, as he was returning from the house of his mistress; their disappearances had disturbed nobody; but at length M. Colbert all at once raised the mask, and caused the affair to be published; it is being cried by sound of trumpet, at this moment in Paris, and, in truth, monseigneur, there is scarcely anybody but yourself ignorant of the event.'

Fouquet began to walk about in his chamber with an uneasiness that became more and more serious.

'What do you decide upon, monseigneur?' said Gourville.

'If it were really as easy as you say, I would go to the king,' cried Fouquet. 'But as I go to the Louvre, I will pass by the Hôtel de Ville. We shall see if the sentence is signed.'

'Incredulity! thou art the pest of all great minds,' said Gourville, shrugging his shoulders.

'Gourville!'

‘Yes,’ continued he, ‘and incredulity! thou ruinest, as contagion destroys the most robust health; that is to say, in an instant.’

‘Let us go,’ cried Fouquet; ‘desire the door to be opened, Gourville.’

‘Be cautious,’ said the latter, ‘the Abbé Fouquet is there.’

‘Ah! my brother,’ replied Fouquet, in a tone of annoyance; ‘he is there, is he? he knows all the ill news, then, and is rejoiced to bring it to me, as usual. The devil! if my brother is there, my affairs are bad, Gourville; why did you not tell me that sooner: I should have been the more readily convinced.’

‘Monseigneur calumniates him,’ said Gourville, laughing; ‘if he is come, it is not with a bad intention.’

‘What, do you excuse him?’ cried Fouquet; ‘a fellow without a heart, without ideas; a devourer of wealth.’

‘He knows you are rich.’

‘And would ruin me.’

‘No, but he would have your purse. That is all.’

‘Enough! enough! A hundred thousand crowns per month, during two years. *Corbleu!* it is I that pay, Gourville, and I know my figures.’ Gourville laughed in a silent, sly manner. ‘Yes, yes, you mean to say it is the king pays,’ said the superintendent. ‘Ah, Gourville, that is a vile joke; this is not the place.’

‘Monseigneur, do not be angry.’

‘Well, then, send away the Abbé Fouquet; I have not a sou.’ Gourville made a step towards the door. ‘He has been a month without seeing me,’ continued Fouquet, ‘why could he not be two months?’

‘Because he repents of living in bad company,’ said Gourville, ‘and prefers you to all his bandits.’

‘Thanks for the preference! You make a strange advocate, Gourville, to-day—the advocate of the Abbé Fouquet!’

‘Eh! but everything and every man has a good side—their useful side, monseigneur.’

‘The bandits whom the Abbé keeps in pay and drink have their useful side, have they? Prove that, if you please.’

‘Let the circumstance arise, monseigneur, and you will be very glad to have these bandits under your hand.’

‘You advise me, then, to be reconciled to the Abbé?’ said Fouquet, ironically.

‘Bah! why should she think I would reproach her? Poor woman, she vastly deceives herself.’

“See him yourself,” said she, “and tell him to beware of M. Colbert.”

‘What! she warned me to beware of her lover?’

‘I have told you she still loves you.’

‘Go on, marquise.’

“M. Colbert,” she added, “came to me two hours ago, to inform me he was appointed intendant.”

‘I have already told you, marquise, that M. Colbert would only be the more in my power for that.’

‘Yes, but that is not all: Marguerite is intimate, as you know, with Madame d’Eymetis and Madame Lyodot.’

‘I know it.’

‘Well, M. Colbert put many questions to her, relative to the fortunes of these two gentlemen, and as to the devotion they had for you.’

‘Oh, as to those two, I can answer for them; they must be killed before they will cease to be mine.’

‘Then, as Madame Yanel was obliged to quit M. Colbert for an instant to receive a visitor, and as M. Colbert is industrious, scarcely was the new intendant left alone, before he took a pencil from his pocket, and, there was paper on the table, began to make notes.’

‘Notes concerning d’Eymetis and Lyodot?’

‘Exactly.’

‘I should like to know what those notes were about.’

‘And that is just what I have brought you.’

‘Madame Yanel has taken Colbert’s notes and sent them to me?’

‘No; but by a chance which resembles a miracle, she has a duplicate of those notes.’

‘How could she get that?’

‘Listen; I told you that Colbert found paper on the table.’

‘Yes.’

‘That he took a pencil from his pocket.’

‘Yes.’

‘And wrote upon that paper.’

‘Yes.’

'Eh! monsieur, everything is to be bought; if not by gold, by intrigue.'
'Nobody knows to the contrary better than you, madame, you to whom I have offered millions.'

'Instead of millions, Fouquet, you should have offered me a true, only and boundless love: I might have accepted that. So you see, still, everything is to be bought, if not in one way, by another.'

'So, Colbert, in your opinion, is in a fair way of bargaining for my place of superintendent. Make yourself easy on that head, my dear marquise; he is not yet rich enough to purchase it.'

'But if he should rob you of it?'

'Ah! that is another thing. Unfortunately, before he can reach me, that is to say, the body of the place, he must destroy, must make a breach in the advanced works, and I am devilishly well fortified, marquise.'

'What you call your advanced works are your creatures, are they not—your friends?'

'Exactly so.'

'And is M. d'Eymeris one of your creatures?'

'Yes, he is.'

'Is M. Lyodot one of your friends?'

'Certainly.'

'M. de Vanin?'

'M. de Vanin! ah! they may do what they like with him, but—'

'But—'

'But they must not touch the others!'

'Well, if you are anxious they should not touch MM. d'Eymeris and Lyodot, it is time to look about you.'

'Who threatens them?'

'Will you listen to me now?'

'Attentively, marquise.'

'Without interrupting me?'

'Speak.'

'Well, this morning Marguerite sent for me.'

'And what did she want with you?'

'"I dare not see M. Fouquet myself," said she.'

'I advise you, monseigneur, not to quarrel with a hundred or a hundred and twenty loose fellows, who, by putting their rapiers end to end, would form a cordon of steel capable of surrounding three thousand men.'

Fouquet darted a searching glance at Gourville, and passing before him,—'That is all very well; let M. l'Abbé Fouquet be introduced,' said he to the footman. 'You are right, Gourville.'

Two minutes after, the Abbé Fouquet appeared in the doorway, with profound reverence. He was a man of from forty to forty-five years of age, half churchman, half soldier,—a spadassin grafted upon an Abbé; upon seeing that he had not a sword by his side, you might be sure he had pistols. Fouquet saluted him more as elder brother than as a minister.

'What can I do to serve you, monsieur l'Abbé?' said he.

'Oh! oh! how coldly you speak to me, brother!'

'I speak like a man who is in a hurry, monsieur.'

The Abbé looked maliciously at Gourville, and anxiously at Fouquet, and said, 'I have three hundred pistoles to pay to M. de Bregi this evening. A play debt, a sacred debt.'

'What next?' said Fouquet bravely, for he comprehended that the Abbé Fouquet would not have disturbed him for such a want.

'A thousand to my butcher, who will supply no more meat.'

'Next?'

'Twelve hundred to my tailor,' continued the Abbé; 'the fellow has made me take back seven suits of my people's, which compromises my liveries, and my mistress talks of replacing me by a farmer of the revenue, which would be a humiliation for the church.'

'What else?' said Fouquet.

'You will please to remark,' said the Abbé, humbly, 'that I have asked nothing for myself.'

'That is delicate, monsieur,' replied Fouquet; 'so, as you see, I wait.'

'And I ask nothing, oh! no,—it is not for want of need, though, I assure you.'

The minister reflected for a minute. 'Twelve hundred pistoles to the tailor; that seems a great deal for clothes,' said he.

'I maintain a hundred men,' said the Abbé, proudly; 'that is a charge, I believe.'

'Why a hundred men?' said Fouquet. 'Are you a Richelieu or a Mazarin, to require a hundred men as a guard? What use do you make of these men?—speak.'

'And do you ask me that?' cried the Abbé Fouquet; 'ah! how can you put such a question,—why I maintain a hundred men? Ah!'

'Why, yes, I do put that question to you. What have you to do with a hundred men?—answer.'

'Ingrate!' continued the Abbé, more and more affected.

'Explain yourself.'

'Why, monsieur the superintendent, I only want one valet de chambre, for my part, and even if I were alone, could help myself very well; but you, you who have so many enemies—a hundred men are not enough for me to defend you with. A hundred men!—you ought to have ten thousand. I maintain, then, these men in order that in public places, in assemblies, no voice may be raised against you; and without them, monsieur, you would be loaded with imprecations, you would be torn to pieces, you would not last a week; no, not a week, do you understand?'

'Ah! I did not know you were my champion to such an extent, monsieur le Abbé.'

'You doubt it?' cried the Abbé. 'Listen, then, to what happened, no longer ago than yesterday, in the Rue de la Hochette. A man was cheapening a fowl.'

'Well, how could that injure me, Abbé?'

'This way. The fowl was not fat. The purchaser refused to give eighteen sous for it, saying that he could not afford eighteen sous for the skin of a fowl from which M. Fouquet had sucked all the fat.'

'Go on.'

'The joke caused a deal of laughter,' continued the Abbé; 'laughter at your expense, death to the devils! and the canaille were delighted. The joker added, "Give me a fowl fed by M. Colbert, if you like! and I will pay all you ask." And immediately there was a clapping of hands. A frightful scandal! you understand; a scandal which forces a brother to hide his face.'

Fouquet coloured. 'And you veiled it?' said the superintendent.

'No, for so it happened I had one of my men in the crowd; a new recruit from the provinces, one M. Menneville, whom I like very much. He made his way through the press, saying to the joker: "*Mille barbes!* Monsieur the

'Fouquet! Fouquet! Is this the way you always treat the poor creatures you desert?'

'Why, you surely are not going to undertake the defence of Madame Vanel?'

'Yes, I will undertake it; for, I repeat, she loves you still, and the proof is she saves you.'

'But your interposition, marquise; that is very cunning on her part. No angel could be more agreeable to me, or could lead me more certainly to salvation. But, let me ask you, do you know Marguerite?'

'She was my convent friend.'

'And you say that she has informed you that Monsieur Colbert was named intendant?'

'Yes, she did.'

'Well, enlighten me, marquise; granted Monsieur Colbert is intendant—so be it. In what can an intendant, that is to say my subordinate, my clerk, give me umbrage or injure me, even if he is Monsieur Colbert?'

'You do not reflect, monsieur, apparently,' replied the marquise.

'Upon what?'

'This: that Monsieur Colbert hates you.'

'Hates me?' cried Fouquet. 'Good heavens! marquise, whence do you come? where can you live? Hates me! why all the world hates me, he, of course, as others do.'

'He more than others.'

'More than others—let him.'

'He is ambitious.'

'Who is not, marquise.'

'Yes, but with him ambition has no bounds.'

'I am quite aware of that, since he made it a point to succeed me with Madame Vanel.'

'And obtained his end; look at that.'

'Do you mean to say he has the presumption to pass from intendant to superintendent?'

'Have you not yourself already had the same fear?'

'Oh! oh!' said Fouquet, 'to succeed with Madame Vanel is one thing, to succeed me with the king is another. France is not to be purchased so easily as the wife of a maître des comptes.'

'No, no, on the contrary, demand it of me; require me to tell it to you instantly, and not to allow myself to be turned aside by any feeling whatever. Fouquet, my friend! it is of immense importance.'

'You astonish me, marquise; I will even say you almost frighten me. You, so serious, so collected; you who know the world we live in so well. Is it, then, important?'

'Oh! very important.'

'In the first place, how did you come here?'

'You shall know that presently; but first to something of more consequence.'

'Speak, marquise, speak! I implore you, have pity on my impatience.'

'Do you know that Colbert is made intendant of the finances?'

'Bah! Colbert, little Colbert.'

'Yes, Colbert, little Colbert.'

'Mazarin's factotum?'

'The same.'

'Well! what do you see so terrific in that, dear marquise? little Colbert is intendant; that is astonishing I confess, but is not terrible.'

'Do you think the king has given, without pressing motive, such a place to one you call a little cuistre?'

'In the first place, is it positively true that the king has given it to him?'

'It is so said.'

'Ay, but who says so?'

'Everybody.'

'Everybody, that's nobody; mention some one likely to be well informed who says so.'

'Madame Vanel.'

'Ah! now you begin to frighten me in earnest,' said Fouquet, laughing; 'if any one is well informed, or ought to be well informed, it is the person you name.'

'Do not speak ill of poor Marguerite, Monsieur Fouquet, for she still loves you.'

'Bah! indeed? That is scarcely credible. I thought little Colbert, as you said just now, had passed over that love, and left the impression upon it of a spot of ink or a strain of grease.'

false joker, here's a thrust for Colbert!" "And one for Fouquet," replied the joker. Upon which they drew in front of the cook's shop, with a hedge of the curious round them, and five hundred as curious at the windows.'

'Well?' said Fouquet.

'Well, monsieur, my Menneville spitted the joker, to the great astonishment of the spectators, and said to the cook:—"Take this goose, my friend, for it is fatter than your fowl." That is the way, monsieur,' ended the Abbé, triumphantly, 'in which I spend my revenues; I maintain the honour of the family, monsieur.' Fouquet hung his head. 'And I have a hundred as good as he,' continued the Abbé.

'Very well,' said Fouquet, 'give the account to Gourville, and remain here this evening.'

'Shall we have supper?'

'Yes, there will be supper.'

'But the chest is closed.'

'Gourville will open it for you. Leave us, monsieur! Abbé, leave us.'

'Then we are friends?' said the Abbé, with a bow.

'Oh, yes, friends. Come, Gourville.'

'Are you going out? You will not stay to supper, then?'

'I shall be back in an hour; rest easy, Abbé.' Then aside to Gourville,—'Let them put to my English horses,' said he, 'and direct the coachman to stop at the Hôtel de Ville de Paris.'

The marquise looked at Fouquet, on his knees at her feet, and there was in the looks of the woman a strange mixture of love and melancholy. 'Oh!' at length murmured she, 'would that I were she who has the right of seeing you every minute, of speaking to you every instant! would that I were she who might watch over you, she who would have no need of mysterious springs to summon and cause to appear, like a sylph, the man she loves, to look at him for an hour, and then see him disappear in the darkness of a mystery, still more strange at his going out than at his coming in. Oh! that would be to live like a happy woman!'

'Do you happen, marquise,' said Fouquet, smiling, 'to be speaking of my wife?'

'Yes, certainly, of her I spoke.'

'Well, you need not envy her lot, marquise; of all the women with whom I have had any relations, Madame Fouquet is the one I see the least of, and who has the least intercourse with me.'

'At least, monsieur, she is not reduced to place, as I have done, her hand upon the ornament of a glass to call you to her; at least you do not reply to her by the mysterious, alarming sound of a bell, the spring of which comes from I don't know where; at least you have not forbidden her to endeavour to discover the secret of these communications under pain of breaking off forever your connections with her, as you have forbidden all who come here before me, and who will come after me.'

'Dear marquise, how unjust you are, and how little do you know what you are doing in thus exclaiming against mystery; it is with mystery alone we can love without trouble; it is with love without trouble alone that we can be happy. But let us return to ourselves, to that devotion of which you were speaking, or rather let me labour under a pleasing delusion, and believe this devotion is love.'

'Just now,' repeated the marquise, passing over her eyes a hand that might have been a model for the graceful contours of antiquity; 'just now I was prepared to speak, my ideas were clear and bold; now I am quite confused, quite troubled; I fear I bring you bad news.'

'If it is to that bad news I owe your presence, marquise, welcome be even that bad news! or rather, marquise, since you allow that I am not quite indifferent to you, let me hear nothing of the bad news, but speak of yourself.'